Breakneck

China's Quest to Engineer the Future

Dan Wang. W. W. Norton, August 26, 2025. 288 pages.
Companion Guide
Prepared September 05, 2026
Spoiler tier: full. This is nonfiction, and the guide discusses the book's arguments, evidence, and conclusions in detail.

Quick Take

Dan Wang spent six years in China as a technology analyst watching factories get built, then sat out the Shanghai lockdown in an apartment while the food delivery system failed. Breakneck is what came out of that. Its argument fits in one sentence, which is both the reason it sold and the reason critics keep swinging at it: China is an engineering state that cannot stop building, and the United States has become a lawyerly society that cannot stop blocking. The book is short, roughly 288 pages, written in a braid of travelogue, memoir, and policy argument, and it moves. It hit the New York Times bestseller list, landed on the Financial Times and Schroders Business Book of the Year shortlist next to Ezra Klein and Derek Thompson's Abundance, and drew best-of-year nods from The New Yorker, the FT, and NPR. Verdict: read it. Read it knowing that the China half rests on a decade of reporting on the ground and the America half rests largely on assertion, which is the one complaint nearly every serious reviewer makes. The framework is a lens, not a proof. Wang himself is more careful than his own slogan, and the most valuable thing in the book is not the engineers-versus-lawyers line at all. It is his account of process knowledge, which is a genuinely useful idea about where capability actually lives.

About the Author

Dan Wang was born in Yunnan, in southwest China. His family emigrated in 2000, when he was seven, arriving with a few hundred dollars just before the Chinese boom really took off. Wang calls this one of several economic mistakes of his parents, which is the kind of line that tells you what the book is going to sound like. He grew up in Ottawa and Toronto, spent time in the Royal Canadian Army Cadets, then finished high school in the Philadelphia suburbs.

He studied economics and philosophy at the University of Rochester, dropped out in his junior year to work at Shopify in Toronto, and got pulled back to finish his degree through a study-abroad program in Freiburg, Germany. He also worked at Flexport and, briefly, the Philadelphia Museum of Art. In 2017 he moved to China as a technology analyst for Gavekal Dragonomics, first in Hong Kong, then Beijing, then Shanghai, covering semiconductors and clean-tech manufacturing until 2023. He was then a visiting scholar at Yale Law School's Paul Tsai China Center, and is now a research fellow at Stanford's Hoover Institution.

Two facts about that path do real work in the book. First, he is Chinese-born and Western-raised, which makes him a partial outsider in both countries and lets him write about each without the defensiveness of a native. Second, he is a working supply-chain analyst rather than an academic China specialist, so his instinct is to go look at the factory. The Yale Law fellowship is not incidental either. Living among lawyers is part of how the second half of his argument formed.

Before the book, Wang was already widely read for his annual letters, long year-end essays circulated heavily in finance, tech, and China-watching circles. Breakneck is those letters, seven of them written between 2017 and 2023, rebuilt into a single argument. Six were about China. One was about the United States.

What the Critics Say

The praise

Reception was strong and mainstream. Tunku Varadarajan in the Wall Street Journal called it a brilliant book, equal parts gripping and depressing. The Economist called the engineering state a useful way to think about industrial competition. John Thornhill in the Financial Times said Wang deftly mixes data-rich analysis with vivid personal anecdotes and punchy opinions. Chris Miller, who wrote Chip War, called it an illuminating account of China's dizzying rise and deepening pathologies. Tyler Cowen named it the best recent book on China and one of the best books of 2025.

> *"Once you learn this way of seeing, you cannot unsee it as you think about both superpowers." Jason Furman, five-star Goodreads review*

On the awards side: New York Times bestseller, peaking around number three by Wang's own account; shortlisted for the 2025 FT and Schroders Business Book of the Year alongside Abundance, House of Huawei, Chokepoints, and How Progress Ends; New Yorker Best Book of the Year; FT Best Book of the Year; NPR Books We Love. Goodreads has it at 4.08 across roughly 12,000 ratings. For a debut nonfiction book by an analyst in his thirties, that is unusual, and it reflects how large the annual-letter audience already was before the book existed.

The criticism, which is remarkably consistent

Five independent reviewers converge on the same complaint: the China half is reported, the America half is asserted. Wang spent a decade on the ground in China and comparatively little time reporting the United States, and it shows in the density of evidence.

Dylan Gyauch-Lewis, writing in The Sling, calls the Tech Power, Zero-Covid, and Fortress China chapters the strongest and says the lawyerly society is underdeveloped by comparison. He argues Wang underrates the role lawyers play in protecting citizens from powerful private interests and in preventing authoritarian drift, and he challenges the lawyers-per-capita metric Wang leans on.

Jordan McGillis in City Journal says Wang's American prescriptions, remember the engineering heritage and diversify the elite, are too small for the problem he has described.

Charles Yang in American Affairs is largely sympathetic and still concedes three things: the book lacks hard data on the actual impact of engineers in government, engineers never dominated American government historically even during the great build-outs, and Wang skips the financial rebalancing China performed to drive investment. That is a friendly reviewer naming the evidentiary hole.

Yi-Ling Liu in the New York Review of Books makes the sharpest moral objection. She argues corporate power, not procedure, shapes American infrastructure, and that Wang largely neglects the hukou household registration system and the migrant-labor exploitation that made

Chinese manufacturing cheap in the first place. American readers finish the book without a clear sense of who paid for the bridges.

The Republic adds a nice historical jab: Tocqueville was already describing lawyers as America's superior political class in the 1830s, well before the 1960s pivot point Wang uses.

Noah Smith's five structural objections

Noah Smith's review is the most systematic attack on the framework and worth reading alongside the book. His five points:

1. America was already lawyer-dominated during the railroad boom, the interstate highway program, and the New Deal, and built prodigiously anyway.
2. The gap may simply reflect where each economy sits on the development curve, not culture or professional training.
3. Japan is the killer counterexample. Its bureaucracy is dominated by law majors, and it sustains high capital investment and world-class manufacturing. If the frame were right, Japan should not exist.
4. Alternative causes are available: the planning impulse inherited from communism, a temporary industrialization phase, ordinary coordination failures.
5. Manufacturing's declining share of GDP suggests engineering-dominated governance is a phase rather than a permanent advantage.

Smith reduces it to one good question: is modern China America with different leaders, or America seventy-five years ago? Wang does not have a clean answer to the Japan objection.

Reader-level dissent

The Goodreads split is clean and instructive. One-star and two-star reviewers use words like reductionist, trope, and laughably reductive, and they want causal proof the book does not offer. Five-star reviewers praise exactly the opposite quality. Jasmine Sun's line captures the sympathetic read: Wang sits in China's complexities without watering down either side, and the achievements coexist with the atrocities. Whether you find the book profound or glib depends mostly on whether you want a lens or a proof.

Themes and What Makes It Work

How the book is built

Seven chapters and an introduction: 1. Engineers vs. Lawyers. 2. Building. 3. Tech Power. 4. One Child. 5. Zero-Covid. 6. Fortress China. 7. Learning to Love Engineers. Then acknowledgments, notes, and suggestions for further reading, with roughly nine percent of the page count given to citations.

The architecture is the argument, and it is easy to miss. Chapters one through three sell you the engineering state. Chapters four through six demolish it using the exact same logic. Chapter

seven turns the mirror on America and on Wang's own family. Any summary that stops after the bridges and the solar panels has read a different, much worse book.

The frame: sledgehammer and gavel

> *"China is an engineering state, which brings a sledgehammer to problems both physical and social." Against "America's lawyerly society," where "everything is gavelled to a halt."*

Note the asymmetry Wang builds in deliberately. The sledgehammer is a tool that works and also maims. The gavel is a tool that protects and also paralyzes. Neither image is a compliment.

Society as plumbing

Wang's definition of the engineering state is the load-bearing idea and it is more specific than the slogan. An engineering state views society as liquid flows, in which all human activity can be directed, restricted, increased, or blocked like water through valves. He calls the mindset awfully literal-minded, says engineers do not know how to persuade, and jokes that engineers cannot take a joke. He describes the Party regulating society as if it were a series of pipes, and characterizes the CCP as a hybrid of the Catholic Church and the Sicilian Mafia, with an incredible sense of omerta.

The hard datum underneath: by 2002, all nine members of the Politburo Standing Committee were trained engineers. Xi Jinping is a chemical engineer by training.

This metaphor is what lets Wang treat the triumphs and the atrocities as one phenomenon instead of two. High-speed rail and the one-child policy are both flow-control problems to an engineer. That is the whole book in one move.

The bike ride that opens it

Breakneck opens with a five-day, nearly 400-mile bicycle ride Wang took in 2021 from Guiyang to Chongqing, through Guizhou, on a Giant racing bike he contrasts with the Maoist-era Flying Pigeon. The organizing question: how is it that China's poorest provinces have better infrastructure than America's richest states? Guizhou's per-capita income is around $8,000. It holds 45 of the world's 100 highest bridges, 11 airports, 5,000 miles of expressways, and working high-speed rail.

That is the book's best single piece of evidence and also its rhetorical signature. Wang argues by pedaling through a place and describing it, not by opening with a literature review.

Process knowledge, the idea most likely to outlive the slogan

Wang splits technology into three parts: tooling, written instructions such as patents and blueprints, and unwritten expertise that lives in workers' hands and heads. That third part is process knowledge, what the Greeks called metis. His compressed version: technology ultimately is people.

> *"Viewing technology as people and process knowledge isn't only more accurate; it also empowers our sense of agency." (p. 75) and "Too many people have argued away the strategic importance of manufacturing." (p. 91)*

The claim is that process knowledge compounds the way capital does. China's roughly 100 million manufacturing workers generate new process knowledge continuously. America, having outsourced production, has lost the tacit knowledge of how to design and run a factory, and blueprints will not restore it. Bell Labs invented the solar cell. Chinese firms own the value chain.

This reframes the innovation debate in a way that survives even if you reject the engineers-versus-lawyers frame entirely. America celebrates the moment of invention. China captured the far larger prize of mass production. Wang's blunt version: if you can't make the simple things, you also can't make the complex things.

Shenzhen and the guitar county

Wang calls Shenzhen a community of engineering practice. It went from 300,000 people in 1980 to 18 million by 2020. Apple's supply chain trained hundreds of thousands of workers a year in advanced electronics, and those skills did not stay inside Foxconn. Engineers moved between firms and founded DJI and BYD, exploiting the component ecosystem smartphones had created. Now Xiaomi, a phone company, builds electric vehicles, and BYD, a carmaker, designs its own chips. Wang uses Shenzhen explicitly as a foil for Silicon Valley: the Valley's stagnant downtowns and broken public infrastructure against Shenzhen's density and efficiency.

The smaller and stranger version is Zheng'an county in Guizhou, which turns out to be the world's largest guitar-making center, producing something like 30 percent of China's guitars. It happened half by accident. Workers who had migrated to Guangdong's export factories came home, and the local government pulled them back with infrastructure, tax benefits, and an appeal to familiar food and culture, dovetailing with Beijing's rural revitalization push. It is a good story because it shows the engineering state working at county scale, and shows process knowledge physically migrating with people.

The vetocracy critique, and who it actually hurts

The numbers Wang uses to anchor this are the ones book clubs argue about. Beijing to Shanghai high-speed rail: built between 2008 and 2011 for roughly $36 billion. California high-speed rail: seventeen years in, $117 to $128 billion projected, unfinished. China deploys something like 300 gigawatts of solar a year, has around 40 nuclear plants under construction, and generates about two and a half times the electricity of the United States. It built a national highway system rivaling America's in half the time.

Wang's account of how America got here is fairer than the slogan suggests. He argues the legal-professional elite emerged after 1970 as a legitimate correction to Robert Moses-era overreach, then hardened into a litigious vetocracy in which the country's smartest people are channeled toward blocking rather than building. Environmental impact statements spanning election

cycles. Housing dying in committee. Permits gathering dust. Funded programs like rural broadband and the EV charger buildout showing minimal completion years later.

The part that gets least attention is the class argument, and it is the reason the book found readers across the political spectrum. Wang insists the costs of proceduralism are regressive. The losers are the people buried under paperwork applying for SNAP benefits, riding dilapidated public transit, and waiting for housing that never gets built. He argues America cannot remain a great power while committed to a system that works well mostly for the wealthy and well-connected. That is a left-populist conclusion arrived at by a Hoover fellow.

The hinge: One Child, Zero-Covid, Fortress China

Chapter four is the moral center of the book. Wang documents the one-child policy: by official statistics, more than 300 million abortions and roughly 100 to 134 million sterilizations across about thirty-five years, plus approximately 40 million missing girls from sex-selective practices. Charles Yang highlights Wang's account of a Shandong party secretary enforcing zero births for 100 days to hit a quota. Wang has said the policy remains understudied and under-theorized, that the anger among survivors is still intense, and that he wrote the chapter during his wife's miscarriage.

Hollis Robbins, reviewing the book as a literary critic, makes the charge that should stick: most reviewers skated past this chapter, admiring the bridges while averting their eyes from the sterilizations. That is precisely the bird's-eye pathology Wang is diagnosing, reproduced by his own readers.

Chapter five is the memoir spine. Wang was in Shanghai for the 2022 lockdown, which he calls the greatest lockdown ever imposed in human history, 25 million people for eight to twelve weeks. The government's food delivery failed and families rationed for their children. He notes the grim accuracy of a China Daily headline reading Shanghai Has No Plans for City Lockdown: the city had literally made no plans for confining 25 million people. Yang cites the detail of lockdown drones broadcasting an instruction to repress your soul's yearning for freedom. Maura Cunningham summarizes the chapter's logic well: engineers will simply follow the science until it leads to total immiseration. Wang connects it to run, the wave of young Chinese leaving the country entirely.

Chapter six covers Xi-era securitization: the turn away from globalization, the obsession with energy, food, and technological self-reliance, and the extension of technocratic logic into repression in Tibet and Xinjiang. This is also where the book has an acknowledged hole. Wang cut deeper Xinjiang coverage because he had no personal reporting from there, and readers have noticed the absence of a full treatment of the internment camps and the Uyghur surveillance apparatus. His own framework predicts Xinjiang more cleanly than anything else in the book, and the book does not fully deliver it. Worth naming plainly.

What he actually recommends

The prescription is deliberately asymmetric. Wang told Tyler Cowen that America should become about 20 percent more engineering-minded, and that China needs to be about 50 percent more lawyerly. He is not saying meet in the middle. He is saying the two deficits are different sizes and different kinds.

On the American side, specifically: stop deporting and visa-blocking skilled foreign engineers; stop the arbitrary self-sabotage, and he names presidential hostility to wind turbines; welcome Chinese manufacturing investment the way Detroit eventually absorbed Japanese automakers, because factories transfer managerial expertise and seed labor ecosystems; and prioritize cultivating process knowledge over fixating on patents.

He refuses the easy version on the Chinese side. China cannot simply import legalism, he argues, because it lacks the centuries of church, aristocracy, and merchant resistance to central power that produced Western law. There is no clean fix on offer for either country, which is why reviewers on both flanks find the ending unsatisfying.

The lines that cut against a comfortable reading

- "50% of China's economy is dysfunctional, but 5% goes splendidly well."
- "Sometimes the only thing scarier than China's problems are Beijing's solutions."
- The Chinese government is bad at listening to people, so its mistakes often have to get really big before they are corrected. (Dan Davies' rendering)
- "It's unfortunate that the U.S. is turning into some of the worst aspects of China. What we have in America is a move towards authoritarianism without the good stuff."
- "I am skeptical of any argument that says that authoritarian systems cannot innovate." He cites Stalin's USSR and Nazi Germany, which is also the strongest argument against his own prescription.

He also warns that Xi's purges and centralization are eroding cadre confidence and may be degrading the execution capacity the whole book is built on. The engineering state may be dismantling itself.

The prose

Wang chose three registers, historical writing, memoir, and travelogue, and braided them deliberately. Yi-Ling Liu describes the result as reading like a compilation of seven new letters, each touching on one aspect of Chinese society. Hollis Robbins, a literary critic, singles out the paragraph architecture and sentence-level linkage for praise, which is not something China books usually get.

Wang's own account of method is worth passing along to any writing student. He says he pays attention to cadences, beat, and the musicality of effect, and that he learned partly by recopying Mozart scores by hand and by retyping New Yorker articles to internalize the choices the author

made. Dan Davies calls the book racy and outspoken and contrasts its conversational energy with the more measured tone of Abundance.

Where it sits next to Abundance

Noah Smith called Breakneck a companion volume to Klein and Thompson's Abundance, and that is the most useful framing for an American reader. In Wang's vocabulary, the abundance movement is an effort to make America less lawyerly and more engineering. Wang supports the aim and explicitly cautions against overdoing it, since the entire back half of his book is a catalog of what unchecked engineering does to people. Abundance diagnoses the blockage. Breakneck shows what the unblocked version costs. The three authors recorded an episode together on ChinaTalk before publication, and both books made the same FT shortlist.

What You Might Not Know

- The book is a rewrite of Wang's seven annual letters, written 2017 through 2023. Six were about China, one about the United States. They are still free online at danwang.co, and there is no archive page, so you have to type the URL pattern directly: danwang.co/2023-letter/, danwang.co/2021-letter/, and so on. The 2019 and 2021 letters carry the industrial-capability material that became the book's spine.
- Wang deliberately kept it under 300 pages, saying he preferred criticism that the book was too short over criticism that it was too long.
- What got cut: the Three Gorges Dam, and a fuller treatment of Xinjiang. In both cases because he had no personal reporting from those places. That decision is the honest source of the book's most common substantive criticism.
- He wrote the One Child chapter during his wife's miscarriage.
- The Chinese title he gives is 突破：中国探索构建未来.
- He suspects mixed ethnic ancestry, possibly Tibetan or Wa, through a grandmother whose origins are cheerfully unknown, and treats that as part of why he feels like an outsider in both countries.
- On Yunnan, his birthplace: he calls it China's freest province, far away in the southwestern mountains and mostly spared sustained attention from the imperial center.
- He has said the final chapter was much easier to write than the first.
- On Beijing, to Tyler Cowen: a Western Pyongyang, a Stalinist no-fun zone.

On Screen and In Your Ears

There is no film, television, or documentary adaptation, and no option deal has been reported as of September 2026. Do not go looking for one.

There are two audiobook editions with different narrators, which trips people up. The US edition is narrated by Jonathan Yen for Kalorama, Norton's audio imprint, at 9 hours 59 minutes, released alongside the hardcover on August 26, 2025. The UK edition is narrated by Kevin Shen

for Penguin Audio. Neither is author-narrated, which is worth knowing given how much of the book is first-person reportage from Beijing, Shanghai, and Yunnan.

The closest thing to a video companion is the Hoover Institution book talk filmed October 27, 2025 at Stanford, free on YouTube and roughly a class period long. It is a home-crowd seminar with real question and answer rather than a promo stop, and it is the best single assignable video. The Asia Society event from September 16, 2025 is the better pick if you want a China-hand audience pushing back on him. The Commonwealth Club also has a video and podcast archive of his appearance.

Podcasts, ranked by purpose. Freakonomics Radio episode 647, from September 19, 2025, is the best general-audience entry point and the cleanest one to assign. Bloomberg's Odd Lots, September 1, 2025, is the most economically granular. Conversations with Tyler, released December 3, 2025, pushes hardest on the framework's edges and is the best one for the man rather than the argument. The ChinaTalk episode from May 10, 2025 puts Wang in a room with Klein and Thompson and is the single highest-leverage listen for the Abundance pairing. The Sinica Podcast and Ezra Klein episodes both have free full transcripts, which makes them the most practical to excerpt for a class.

For a short scholarly-register version of the argument, Wang and Arthur Kroeber published The Real China Model in Foreign Affairs, September/October 2025. Charles Yang's essay The Engineering State in American Affairs is the most valuable single companion piece, because it is a friendly critic converting a diagnosis into actual policy while naming the evidentiary gap.

If You Liked This

The American capacity side

- Abundance, Ezra Klein and Derek Thompson (2025). The essential pairing. Same diagnosis of lawyerly blockage, argued from inside American liberalism without the China mirror.
- Why Nothing Works, Marc J. Dunkelman (2025). The sharpest mechanism-level account of why the lawyerly society got that way, locating the tension inside progressivism itself. This is the part Wang describes more than explains.
- Public Citizens, Paul Sabin (2021). The origin story. How the Nader-era public interest movement built the veto points, from the left, that Wang now indicts.
- The Rise and Fall of American Growth, Robert J. Gordon (2016). The deflationary counterweight to all of the above. If Gordon is right that the 1870 to 1970 surge was a one-time event, then Wang and the abundance camp are both blaming institutions for the exhaustion of a technological wave.

The China side

- How Asia Works, Joe Studwell (2013). The prequel. Land reform, export discipline, financial repression. Read it first and Breakneck's industrial chapters become a regional pattern rather than a Chinese exception.
- Apple in China, Patrick McGee (2025). The best single case study of Wang's thesis inside one company. Where Wang argues at the level of the state, McGee shows capability transferring firm by firm.
- Chip War, Chris Miller (2022). The chokepoint case. Semiconductors are the one domain where the engineering state has not built its way out, which makes this the best available test of the model's limits.

Four books that argue against him, strongest first

- The Rise and Fall of the EAST, Yasheng Huang (2023). The most direct rebuttal. Huang reads the Chinese state as a homogenization machine descended from the imperial exam system, superb at standardizing ideas and correspondingly bad at generating new ones. Where Wang sees an engineering state that builds, Huang sees a conformity machine that will stop innovating.
- Invisible China, Scott Rozelle and Natalie Hell (2020). The empirical undercut, and probably the most useful counter-book for an education audience. Most of China's rural workforce never finished high school. If human capital is the binding constraint, no amount of engineering throughput builds past it.
- Overreach, Susan L. Shirk (2022). The political-science counter. China's problems are self-inflicted and come from the drift to strongman rule, not from what its leaders studied in college. That cuts against the engineers-versus-lawyers premise as an explanatory variable at all.
- Seeing Like a State, James C. Scott (1998). Not about China, and the deepest challenge for exactly that reason. Scott's account of high-modernist state simplification predicts One Child and Zero-Covid as the inherent cost of the engineering mindset, not as correctable aberrations. If Scott is right, Wang's take-the-building-capacity-leave-the-cruelty prescription may be asking for something structurally unavailable.

If you want more

- The Party, Richard McGregor (2010). The Party, not the state, is the operating system. Wang treats that as background.
- Age of Ambition, Evan Osnos (2014). The human texture underneath the engineering, and the best complement to Wang's moves-fast-and-breaks-people register.
- Material World, Ed Conway (2023). Six raw materials as the physical substrate of everything Wang says China builds.

Discussion Questions

The first three are general. The rest are built for a graduate leadership or business communication seminar, on the premise that the students will spend their careers inside exactly the rule-bound, process-heavy public institutions Wang is describing. Questions 5, 7, and 10 each produce a written artifact, so any of them can carry a short assignment rather than just a conversation.

6. Wang's central claim is that China is run by engineers and America by lawyers. Before accepting the frame, test it. What would have to be true for this to be more than a memorable metaphor? A sympathetic reviewer concedes the book lacks hard data on the impact of engineers in government. Does the frame survive that concession, and what evidence would falsify it?
7. Wang argues the engineering state produced both high-speed rail and the one-child policy using the same tool. Is that one capability with two outputs, or two different things bundled under one name? What is at stake in the answer?
8. Wang's implicit prescription is that America should acquire China's building capacity without its coercion. James C. Scott suggests the two are structurally inseparable. Which reading is more persuasive, and why?
9. Leadership. Every organization has engineers and lawyers in Wang's sense: people who optimize for throughput and people who optimize for defensibility. Map your own organization. Who holds which posture, where do they sit, and who wins a disagreement between them? What does that tell you about what your organization is actually built to produce?
10. Public-sector capacity. Identify one process in your organization that was created to prevent a specific harm and now costs more than the harm it prevents. Who has standing to remove it? If the honest answer is nobody, what does that reveal about how institutional rules accumulate, and what would a removal mechanism look like?
11. Bureaucracy and veto points. Paul Sabin shows that many American veto points were built deliberately, from the left, by people trying to protect the public from unaccountable power. Take one procedural constraint in your own setting, a public comment requirement, a due process protocol, a procurement rule, and argue both sides: legitimate protection, and capacity tax. Where do you land, and what moved you?
12. Process versus rules. Rules constrain. Processes coordinate. When your organization faces a failure, does its reflex response add a rule, redesign a process, or build a capability? Track your last three responses to failure. What pattern do you find, and what does it predict about the next one?
13. Business communication. Wang made an argument about industrial policy legible to a general audience by giving it two nouns. That framing carried the book onto bestseller lists. Analyze the move. What does the frame make visible, what does it hide, and where is the line between clarifying and oversimplifying? Then do it: take a genuinely complex problem in your own organization and build one frame for it that would survive scrutiny from someone who knows the details.

14. Communication and audience. Wang writes for policymakers, general readers, and China specialists at once, and each group reads a different book. Take one chapter and rewrite its core claim three ways: for a governing board with fifteen minutes, for the staff who would have to implement it, and for a skeptical external audience that assumes you have an agenda. What survives all three? What does that tell you about which parts of the argument are load-bearing?
15. Capacity and human capital. Scott Rozelle argues China's real constraint is that most of its rural workforce never finished high school, a ceiling no engineering state can build past. If that is right, education is the binding constraint on national capacity, not permitting or procurement. Does that reframe Wang's entire argument? What does it imply about the leverage of the institutions you actually run?

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